

Building with AI Buildathon Guide by iBuildWith.ai

Use this guide during the Buildathon to help you turn an idea into something small, useful, and demoable. You will only have about an hour to build, so keep your idea simple.

The goal is not to build something perfect. The goal is to start building.

Section 1: Top 20 Tips for Building with AI

1. Start with the problem, not the app

Before asking AI to build something, explain the problem you are trying to solve.

2. Tell AI who the app is for

AI gives better suggestions when it understands the audience.

3. Describe the outcome you want

Focus on what the user should be able to do when the app works.

4. Ask AI to ask you questions first

Do not let AI jump straight into building. Have it clarify your idea first.

5. Build the smallest useful version

You are not building the whole product tonight. You are building something small enough to explain and demo.

6. Limit the first version to 3 core features

More features usually means more confusion. Keep the first version simple.

7. Give AI clear constraints

AI gives better suggestions when it knows the limits. Tell it how much time you have, what the demo needs to show, and what you do not want to include.

8. Ask for a simple build plan

Before building, ask AI to break the work into clear steps.

9. Work one screen or section at a time

Do not ask AI to design the entire app at once. Start with the first screen or main interaction.

10. Keep asking AI to simplify

AI often gives you too much. Push it to remove anything that is not needed.

11. Ask AI what to skip

Knowing what not to build is just as important as knowing what to build.

12. Use AI as a product partner

Do not only ask AI to write code or create screens. Ask it to help shape the idea.

13. Make the demo the goal

Build toward something you can show, not something that is fully complete.

14. Fake what does not matter yet

For a demo, some things can be mocked, manually explained, or represented with sample data.

15. Use sample data

Sample data makes your app easier to test and demo.

16. When stuck, show AI what happened

Do not just say, "It does not work." Explain what you expected and what happened instead.

17. Ask AI to explain confusing parts simply

If AI gives you something you do not understand, ask it to explain without jargon.

18. Save time near the end for demo prep

Do not build until the last second. Stop and prepare what you will say.

19. Focus on progress, not polish

The first version does not need to look perfect. It needs to communicate the idea.

20. End with what you would improve next

A good demo does not need to be finished. It should show what you built and where it could go next.

Section 2: Top 20 Do's and Don'ts for Building with AI

1. Start with the problem, not the app

Don't:

Build me an app.

Do:

I want to help people remember who they need to follow up with and what they promised to send.

2. Tell AI who the app is for

Don't:

Make this useful for everyone.

Do:

This app is for small business owners who are not technical and need a simple way to manage customer follow-ups.

3. Describe the outcome you want

Don't:

Add some features for tracking contacts.

Do:

At the end, the user should be able to add a contact, set a follow-up date, and see who needs attention today.

4. Ask AI to ask you questions first

Don't:

Start building this right away.

Do:

Before suggesting features or building anything, ask me as many questions as you need to better understand the idea.

5. Build the smallest useful version

Don't:

Build the full product with every feature I might need.

Do:

Help me reduce this idea to the smallest useful version I can demo tonight.

6. Limit the first version to 3 core features

Don't:

Give me a long list of features to include.

Do:

What are the 3 most important features for the first demo?

7. Tell AI what tool you are using

Don't:

Tell me how to build this.

Do:

I am using Claude Code. Give me step-by-step instructions that work for Claude Code.

8. Ask for a simple build plan

Don't:

Just start creating everything.

Do:

Give me a simple build plan I can follow in one hour.

9. Work one screen or section at a time

Don't:

Design the entire app all at once.

Do:

Let's start with the main screen only. What should be on it?

10. Keep asking AI to simplify

Don't:

Add more advanced features.

Do:

This is too much for tonight. Simplify it into something I can demo.

11. Ask AI what to skip

Don't:

Assume everything needs to be built tonight.

Do:

What should I skip for the first version so I can finish a clear demo?

12. Use AI as a product partner

Don't:

Only write the code.

Do:

Help me think through the audience, problem, user flow, and demo before we build.

13. Make the demo the goal

Don't:

Make this production-ready.

Do:

What do I need to build so this is clear in a 5-minute demo?

14. Fake what does not matter yet

Don't:

Build the database, login system, payment system, and admin dashboard first.

Do:

What parts can I fake, mock, explain verbally, or use sample data for tonight?

15. Use sample data

Don't:

Wait until I have real data before building anything.

Do:

Create 5 realistic sample records I can use to test and demo this app.

16. When stuck, show AI what happened

Don't:

It does not work. Fix it.

Do:

I expected X to happen, but Y happened instead. Here is what I tried. Help me fix this in the simplest way.

17. Ask AI to explain confusing parts simply

Don't:

I do not understand this, so I am stuck.

Do:

Explain this in plain English and tell me exactly what I should do next.

18. Save time near the end for demo prep

Don't:

Keep building until the last second.

Do:

Help me create a short demo script for what I built.

19. Focus on progress, not polish

Don't:

Make this perfect before I show it.

Do:

Help me improve this enough to demo, but do not over-polish it.

20. End with what you would improve next

Don't:

Hide everything that is unfinished.

Do:

Help me list 3 things I would improve after tonight so I can mention them in my demo.

Section 3: 10 Small Buildathon Ideas You Can Build Tonight

Use these ideas if you do not know what to build. Each idea is intentionally small enough to start during the Buildathon and demo within a few minutes.

1. Personal Follow-Up Tracker

Build a simple tool that helps someone track who they need to follow up with, when they last contacted them, and what they need to send next.

Keep it small: Use sample contacts and a simple “needs follow-up today” list.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple follow-up tracker for people I need to contact. Keep it small enough to demo in one hour. Ask me 5 questions first, then suggest the smallest demoable version.

2. Meeting Prep Assistant

Build a tool that helps someone prepare for an upcoming meeting by organizing goals, questions, attendees, and talking points.

Keep it small: One form, one generated meeting prep summary.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple meeting prep assistant. It should help a user enter the meeting topic, attendees, goals, and questions, then create a short prep summary. Keep it demoable in one hour.

3. Weekly Meal Idea Generator

Build a simple app or prompt workflow that suggests easy meals based on ingredients someone already has.

Keep it small: Use 5 sample ingredients and generate 3 meal ideas.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a small meal idea generator that creates 3 simple meals from ingredients a user already has. Keep the first version very simple and demoable.

4. Habit Check-In Tracker

Build a simple tracker for 3 daily habits with a basic progress view.

Keep it small: Track today only, or use a few sample days.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple habit check-in tracker for 3 daily habits. I only need a small demo version that lets someone check off habits and see basic progress.

5. Content Idea Generator

Build a simple tool that helps a creator generate blog, newsletter, podcast, or LinkedIn post ideas from a topic.

Keep it small: Input one topic, output 5 ideas.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple content idea generator. A user enters a topic and audience, and it returns 5 useful content ideas. Keep it small enough to demo tonight.

6. Personal Budget Snapshot

Build a simple budget helper that lets someone enter a few expenses and see a basic monthly snapshot.

Keep it small: Use categories like rent, food, subscriptions, transportation, and fun.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple personal budget snapshot tool. A user enters a few monthly expenses and sees a basic summary by category. Keep it simple and demoable.

7. Event Planning Checklist

Build a small tool that creates a checklist for planning an event, meetup, workshop, birthday party, or team gathering.

Keep it small: Input event type and date, output a checklist.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple event planning checklist generator. A user enters the event type, date, and audience, and the tool creates a practical checklist. Keep it small enough for a one-hour demo.

8. Customer FAQ Helper

Build a simple assistant that turns common customer questions into short, friendly answers.

Keep it small: Use 5 sample questions and answers.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple customer FAQ helper. It should take common customer questions and generate short, friendly answers. Keep the first version very small and demoable.

9. Travel Mini-Planner

Build a simple travel planning helper that creates a short itinerary for a day trip or weekend trip.

Keep it small: One destination, one day, 3 suggested activities.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple travel mini-planner. A user enters a destination and travel style, and the tool creates a one-day itinerary with 3 activities. Keep it demoable in one hour.

10. Resume Bullet Improver

Build a simple tool that helps someone rewrite rough resume bullets into clearer, stronger bullets.

Keep it small: Input one rough bullet, output 3 improved versions.

Starter prompt:

Help me build a simple resume bullet improver. A user enters one rough resume bullet, and the tool gives 3 stronger versions. Keep the first version very simple.